VOL. 1 · NO. 27 PRINTED FOR DANIEL PRICE: ONE CUP OF COFFEE

The Morning Newspaper

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 13, 2026 · AUSTIN EDITION

94° / 78° | Overcast, 10% rain, wind 14 mph | Tomorrow: 92° / 78°, overcast | Sunrise 7:31 · Sunset 19:02 | Waxing crescent

Apple Unveils a Full Smart-Home Lineup at Its "Welcome Home" Event

A HomeView display, a redesigned Apple TV 4K, HomePod mini 2 and a camera-and-sensor Home Collection all ship within weeks, Apple's biggest smart-home push yet.

WORLD & TECH

Zelensky: No Early Warning Before Russian Strikes on Kyiv

WORLD · THE NEW YORK TIMES, THE GUARDIAN

President Zelensky said Tuesday that Russia "did not heed" President Trump's call for an energy-sector ceasefire, striking Kyiv overnight with missiles Ukraine had no early warning of. The remark feeds concern in Kyiv that Washington has scaled back the intelligence sharing that once let Ukraine warn civilians ahead of incoming strikes. Separately, a drone strike sank a merchant ship in the Black Sea overnight, leaving eleven crew missing and prompting Bulgaria to summon Russia's ambassador.

Pennsylvania Reports Sixth Measles Death as Cases Top 1,100

WORLD · ARS TECHNICA, THE GUARDIAN

Pennsylvania health officials confirmed a sixth measles-associated death, an unvaccinated 39-year-old woman, as the state's case count climbed past 1,100 across 41 counties. The CDC's own national tally still lists only two measles deaths, underscoring a gap between state and federal reporting on the outbreak. Hospitalizations tied to the outbreak have climbed as well, even as case growth has slowed in most other states.

Anthropic, OpenAI Push for Say Over What AI Evaluators Publish

TECH · REUTERS, VIA TECHMEME

Anthropic and OpenAI have reportedly sought significant control over what outside AI safety evaluators may publish about their models, citing fears that findings could expose trade secrets. Critics say the push could blunt independent scrutiny just as regulators lean more heavily on third-party model evaluations. Neither company has detailed exactly what changes they are asking evaluators to accept.

MARKETS

INDEX	LAST	CHG
S&P 500	7,810.41	+0.04%
Dow Jones	52,041.58	+0.37%
Nasdaq	27,230.54	-0.06%
Russell 2000	2,792.80	-0.06%
VIX	15.30	+0.59%
10-yr yield	5.20	-0.76%
CRYPTO		
Bitcoin	$83,272	+0.72%
Ethereum	$2,507.86	-0.93%
STOCKS		
NVDA	$224.72	-0.71%
AAPL	$342.19	+0.36%
MSFT	$549.34	+1.51%
GOOGL	$355.54	+0.80%
AMZN	$262.26	+1.05%
META	$757.00	+1.89%
AVGO	$354.83	+0.03%
TSLA	$375.04	-0.79%
SPCX	$160.00	-2.09%
BRK-B	$520.29	+0.52%
TSM	$442.07	-0.51%

Wall Street drifted through a mixed, low-volatility session: the Dow added 0.37% while the Nasdaq slipped a touch as chipmakers cooled. Meta and Microsoft led large-cap gains on continued AI infrastructure spending even as Nvidia and Tesla gave back ground. The IMF warned Tuesday that stretched AI valuations could threaten global financial stability if the sector's earnings fail to keep pace with its capital spending, a backdrop for Nvidia's soft session. Small-caps lagged too, with the Russell 2000 slipping for a second session while the VIX ticked up to 15.30, still well under its historical average. Bitcoin held near $83,000 and the 10-year yield eased to 5.20% as traders stayed cautious heading into next week's inflation data.

ON THIS DAY

1307: King Philip IV of France ordered the arrest of the Knights Templar on a Friday the 13th, a purge historians credit with helping cement that date's reputation for bad luck.

FROM THE FEEDS · FULL TEXT IN SECTION B

AEON
Deskilling the Body — how leaning on tech for sensing, walking and remembering is quietly eroding bodily skill.

LONGREADS
Where the Forest Went — one man's turn-of-the-century land deals carved 2.6 million wild acres into parcels for sale.

NAUTILUS
Mere Minutes With AI Causes a Sharp Drop in Persistence — a warning about how fast cognitive offloading sets in.

NAUTILUS
This Is the Oldest Peace Treaty Ever Discovered — and what it still has to teach about ending conflicts.

PSYCHE
What Is Hidden in the Photographs We Keep of Each Other? — on family albums and the stories images leave out.

QUANTA MAGAZINE
Is "Attention" the Essence of Intelligence? — why the mechanism behind modern AI might be more than a math trick.

TRICYCLE
B. R. Ambedkar and the Dalit Quest for Dignity — marking seventy years since his mass conversion to Buddhism.

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Sources: RSS, Open-Meteo, Yahoo Finance, CoinGecko, web

QUANTA MAGAZINE

Is 'Attention' the Essence of Intelligence?

NATALIE WOLCHOVER OCTOBER · QUANTAMAGAZINE.ORG · OCT 12, 2026

A deep look at the mathematical mechanism behind modern AI and why it might be more than a clever trick.

Everything that's swept the world since the 2022 release of ChatGPT — "the AI economy"; data centers; chatbots acting as best friends, doctors, and mathematicians; talk of existential risk — it all starts, in some sense, with an intern in a University of Montreal lab named Dzmitry Bahdanau.

It was 2014. The 23-year-old Belarusian, who had been coding competitively since he was a kid but hadn't done academic research before, was asked to help figure out how to get a computer to translate sentences from English to French. Bahdanau was working with artificial neural networks, which had already shown promise in pattern-recognition tasks such as deciphering handwriting and identifying objects in photos. The networks learn to recognize patterns by strengthening and weakening connections between nodes in response to training data. Bahdanau quietly doubted their potential to achieve anything like human-level intelligence, but his adviser, the computer scientist Yoshua Bengio, and the postdoc on the project, Kyunghyun Cho, were believers. And translation was widely seen as a formidable and interesting problem for neural networks to try to solve.

Translation is not as simple as swapping each English word for a French one. Languages have different grammatical structures and are riddled with idioms and connotations, all of which had long stymied attempts to automate the process. You can't simply implement rules of translation because there are none. But neural networks seemed promising because they learn by example. They can be trained on huge databases of paired English and French sentences to, eventually, absorb the quasi-rules, exceptions, and subtleties.

Results had been mediocre, though; the longer the sentence, the worse neural networks performed. That's because researchers were trying to cram each sentence's data into a fixed amount of memory before decoding the sentence in the target language.

Continued online (full article about 2303 words). Scan, or visit https://www.quantamagazine.org/is-attention-the-essence-of-intelligence-20261012/

NAUTILUS

Mere Minutes With AI Causes a Sharp Drop in Persistence

JAKE CURRIE · NAUTIL.US · OCT 12, 2026

New research on how quickly cognitive offloading to AI tools sets in.

New York City schools took the drastic action of restricting artificial intelligence last month, banning around 600,000 students from pre-K through eighth grade from using the technology. "They learn best when they are wrestling with hard problems, when they're getting it wrong, when they're trying again and finally getting it right," the chancellor of schools Kamar Samuels said of the move. "No app, chatbot, or algorithm can replicate that productive struggle for a child."

Rather than replicate it, AI is promising to eliminate it entirely (at least for adults). Now a new study presented this week at the third annual Conference on Language Modeling is providing more evidence that AI could erode our critical cognitive faculties.

To investigate how AI might shape our long-term learning, AI researchers led by Brian Christian of University of California Berkeley designed a series of test-taking experiments. Adult participants were tasked with solving a series of equations involving fractions (e.g., 5/6 minus 1/3). One group was provided with a ChatGPT window to help, while the other had to slog through solo. After a series of questions, ChatGPT disappeared, leaving the former group to finish the test with nothing but their brains as well.

The researchers found that the members of the ChatGPT group solved the problems at a higher rate than the control group and skipped questions at a lower rate—at least until it was taken away. After the chatbot disappeared, the two groups swapped places, with the brain-only crowd solving at a higher rate and skipping questions at a lower rate.

To find out if the effect extends beyond mathematics, the team repeated the experiment with reading comprehension questions cribbed from SAT exams.

Continued online (full article about 488 words). Scan, or visit https://nautil.us/mere-minutes-with-ai-causes-a-sharp-drop-in-persistence-1285736/

AEON

Deskilling the Body

MELANIE CHALLENGER · AEON.CO · OCT 13, 2026

An essay on how leaning on technology for sensing and navigating is quietly eroding bodily skill.

It is almost four o'clock in the morning. As a woman in my late 40s, I have become prone to waking at this witching hour, as the early sunlight meets the night, sliding across the earth like a red tide. With the rest of my household asleep, and still half in and out of wakefulness myself, I take hold of my phone. With scarcely a thought, I switch from one app to another, scrolling through images and opinions and adverts for no discernible reason beyond habit.

Later, I head for my office and open my laptop to a slew of half-completed documents and an inbox brimming with emails. My stress levels begin to nudge upwards. I have vague memories of what my professional life felt like before smartphones and video calls. I used to do my writing by hand. And I could concentrate for hours at a time, getting little upticks of arousal from lifting my head from the page, letting the hold on my pen loosen, and gazing at the life beyond my window, the light softening on my skin and eyes like snowfall on warm tarmac.

Nowadays, my productive bursts come from caffeine and sugary or salty snacks, even if I try to pick the healthier ones, and from checking my emails or picking up my phone to update my inbox. By the end of the day, the sheer volume of work I expect myself to do, now that digital tools make so much possible, has kept me nailed to my seat. Another day has passed and the hope I'd had that I might have time for a run or a hike outside has been dashed again. I wish I could say that this is atypical.

Continued online (full article about 3432 words). Scan, or visit https://aeon.co/essays/the-more-we-rely-on-tech-the-more-we-deskill-our-bodies

LONGREADS

Where the Forest Went

JAMES WHORTON JR · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 13, 2026

A writer retraces how one man's land deals carved 2.6 million wild acres into parcels for sale.

Thoughtful stories for thoughtless times.

Longreads has published hundreds of original stories—personal essays, reported features, reading lists, and more—and more than 14,000 editor's picks. And they're all funded by readers like you. Become a member today.

James Whorton Jr. | Longreads | October 13, 2026 | 5,932 words (25 minutes)

I live in Edgewood, a subdivision of quarter-acre lots in the town of Brighton, New York. Before the house was here, Edgewood was a farm, and before the farm, there was a forest. On a July day in 1788, a 55-year-old man named Hugh Maxwell set out to cross the forest in straight lines.

Not kind of straight. Maxwell's job was to walk 1,100 miles on ruler-straight lines through this vast, obstacle-filled forest, to divide it into a grid of parcels that could eventually be sold as property. To shrink it down to the scale of human imagination. To look at the forest and see something else in its place.

I first learned about Maxwell from Mary Jo Lanphear, Brighton's town historian. I had gone to Lanphear to research the racially restrictive housing covenants that made home ownership in Brighton exclusive to white people for decades. Whose fault was this? I wanted to know. Some racist real-estate developer? Something to do with the Federal Housing Administration? Lanphear printed out a copy of an old deed linking the Edgewood land to the Phelps and Gorham Company, a group of New England speculators. For a bargain price, Phelps and Gorham had acquired the title to 2.6 million acres of forested country along the Genesee River, in what is now western New York. The company then hired Maxwell—a Revolutionary War veteran, father of seven, and the first recorded white person to pass within shouting distance of the place where I now live—as surveyor.

Continued online (full article about 5900 words). Scan, or visit https://longreads.com/2026/10/13/american-forest-development-property-hugh-maxwell/